Why did the divergence on China policy from 1949 to 1956 not lead to a complete rupture between the US and India? For all their differences, both governments faced a dilemma then that they would continue to face over the next decade and a half: they may not have liked each other's policies, but they needed each other. With China-India comparisons becoming commonplace and gaining strength in the early 1950s, US administrations could not see India fail or go communist like China. As Bowles put it in 1952, it was important to stop communists at the "front door," but also crucial not to "leave [the] backdoor unlatched."[237] For India, the US was an essential component in its plans for development. Development, in turn, was seen as critical for India's defense as well as its political stability. There was a broader political motivation as well—as Bajpai noted, "[The] Prime Minister made [a] great many promises and history may record it was Americans who made it possible for him to keep them."[238]

From the Truman administration's perspective, difficulties with India over China notwithstanding, the communist takeover of China in 1949 and successful military action against UN forces in Korea in winter 1950 made it crucial that India did not "go communist" like China had. A State Department policy review in December 1950 noted that "India has become the pivotal state in non-Communist Asia by virtue of its relative power, stability and influence."[239] An NSC reassessment of South Asia policy in January 1951 stated that if India was lost, "for all practical purposes all of Asia would [be] lost; this would constitute a most serious and threatening blow to the security of the United States."[240] The loss of India would also constitute a political blow to the Truman administration, still suffering from accusations that it had lost China. The loss could happen either through the lack of economic development, leading to political and socioeconomic instability, or through India turning elsewhere for aid because it had not been forthcoming from the US. Consequently, the US needed to aid India's development.

Given Indian officials' public statements, there was little point in the administration arguing to Congress that aid could win India over. Instead, as aid requests bluntly stated, the objective was to prevent India's loss. This formulation was evident in Truman's message to Congress supporting food aid legislation for India in 1951. As presidents after him would, he appealed for aid to India for strategic, symbolic, and humanitarian reasons. Acheson,